

DARDAVIESEDIT

Stunt performing in movies is not for the faint-hearted. I recently met up and chatted with one of Australia's legendary stuntmen, Dar Davies, who revved up his motorcycle and jumped over 25 cars for fun. Amazing showgoers all over Australia, among other interesting death-defying activities.

He's also worked as a professional stuntman on a number of blockbuster Hollywood and Australian movies. Travel Radio Australia, and we're on the sunny Gold Coast in Queensland this month, and I have a very special guest with me. It's Glyn Davies, otherwise known as Dar Davies, Stuntman Extraordinaire.

Davies English. That's right. Now, Glyn, you've been in the stunt world for all your life, really, and you got a very early start.

Tell us about the start, where you came from, and how it all happened. I remember being in military school in Singapore when I was about seven or eight years old, and then my father was in the British military back then, and then we ended up back in Australia for a while. My father took us back to Africa because he'd served in the Belgian Congo with the United Nations, so we ended up going back to Rhodesia.

I know this is very emotional for you. Yeah, you're obviously very close to your father, but you came to Australia. Tell us about how you got here to Australia.

Well, you know, Rhodesia fell in 1978, 1980. The old man died in Botswana, and my mother grabbed the three boys because they were the three brothers. I went through a lot of schools in Australia.

I didn't really fit in. I eventually found my feet in Western Sydney, and was lucky enough to meet a man called Herbie Nelson, and Herbie Nelson was a stunt coordinator from the United Kingdom, and so I was 15, 16 years old, and I met my best mate, Donnie Vaughan, who I'm still a good mate with today, after we were involved in the Sydney Stunt Community, you might call it, and they used to have the Hector's Equity Stunt Grading Office in Sydney and Woolloomooloo. In those days, as a young bloke, you did your best to try to get in there and be part of the stunt community, and it was for all of the local Sydney stuntmen back in the day.

I was lucky enough to get a manager when I was about 17, and I started jumping at the local shows. This is on a motorcycle? Yeah, on the motorcycle, jumping over rows of cars, a bit like Evel Knievel. I mean, I met Evel Knievel when I was 14 years old, and I helped him under a fence at one of his live shows in Orange in New South Wales in 1979, Feb 1979, and we had Young Dale Buggins from Waiyong there, and Dale was the, you know, he was the world record giant back in the day, jumping over 25 cars at Tomago and Newcastle, and, you know, we had Robbie Knievel there, who just passed away the other day, and Evel was there, and so they were very,

very strong male influences on me when I was a young bloke.

For years later, I jumped at Forbes, I jumped at Dubbo, I jumped at Orange, I jumped at Bega, I jumped at Narra, I jumped all over New South Wales, I jumped in South Australia, I jumped in the Northern Territory, and then eventually I went overseas, and I jumped in Europe, France, and jumping over cars. You line up a row of cars, 15, 20 cars, you put a ramp there and you jump over it, and we always jumped the ramp to ground back in the day, you know, it was what it was. I was lucky enough to work with Max Aspin, who was the genius behind Mad Max 2, you know, and I was also very lucky enough to work with Grant Page for many years, for 40 years with Grant and me, we were the best of mates, and Grant was the genius behind Mad Max 1 and Mad Max 3. You know, I've been tight in the stunt game all my life, unfortunately most of the people I know are gone now, unfortunately, that's the way that goes.

All the people that made the legends happen are pretty much gone now, and that's the truth of that. Describe the motorcycles to us, because I know Harley Davidson were very big in that area with the guys, but tell us about your weapons of choice. Well, I used to use Yamaha YZ250s, and they weighed about 100 kilos, 200 pounds, and I used a kicker ramp that got given to me after Dale Buggins passed away in 1981, and it was 28 feet long, 4 feet high, and I'd hit that at, you know, 65, 75 mile an hour, and I'd punch over 150 feet of cars, and it worked for me really well.

I should have changed the design of that ramp, but I never did. Anyway, in 1991, I went for a, well, what we thought was going to be a world record jump over, I don't know, 33, 35 cars at Eastern Creek in Sydney. For once, we built a landing ramp and everything else.

You know, I had a dirt landing ramp, and I was jumping 190, 200 feet ramp to ramp, there's a down ramp at the end, and it was all going well. We had no cameras, we didn't film any of this. Eventually, I hit the ramp at 80, I had 1,440 foot of runoff, and I had a YZ490, and I was running 42 cogs on the back end and 15 on the front, so I was doing 85 mile an hour, and I hit it, and it bottomed out in the ramp and spat me into the air, and the whole thing spun around on me in the air, and I went in head first at 80 miles an hour, and I was unconscious for eight hours, and I woke up in the hospital, and I'd totally broken my shoulder, the motorcycle was not much chop.

I mean, I was a very hammer and tong motorcycle rider. I just go even harder when it didn't work right. I was 26 and broken.

It's not for the faint-hearted. I was good at it. Nine times out of 10 ain't good enough.

That's right. Travel news, features, and interviews from around the world. This is Travel Radio Australia with your host, Jeff Harrison.

Here on the Gold Coast in Queensland, Australia, you were very instrumental at the start of Movie World, and you helped put together a fantastic show called the Police Academy Stunt Show with cars that were on their wheels at 45-degree angles. Tell us a bit about that. You know,

that was Grant Page.

Grant was the first person reigned in to do that, and I was run of a lot of youngstom in that got called up to come and do it through Zen Stunts in Sydney. We put 600 people through their paces, doing handbrake turns, motorcycle jumps, swimming under fire, swinging off ropes, doing all sorts of things that you do as a stunt performer, turning cars around, all that sort of thing you do as a stunt performer. We ended up with like 50 people, and they were the original Police Academy Stunt Show.

Grant left Warner Brothers and went away, and a really amazing stuntman from Adelaide called Vic Wilson took over. Vic was really exceptional. This show, for people wondering what it was like, you sit in an auditorium, and cars would come in chasing people on motorcycles, and the cars actually went up on two wheels.

That was very, very exciting. Well, they did all sorts of things, but it was all gimmicky tricks that you'd find in Hollywood. And so what we'd done is we produced a stunt show that you could do three times a day.

And so they had a permanent cast of people, and there were a dozen people involved, and they had helicopters coming over the top, and explosions, and cars, and motorcycles doing all that sort of thing. Movie World's been running for 30 years, I think, and the audiences never stop. I was really lucky that in 1995, they gave me a phone call and got me in to do the high wire right up the main street of Movie World.

And I did it for 17 days straight. Unfortunately, somebody decided to sabotage it, which that's what happened. Nobody got hurt, but it was what it was.

I met the original people from Hollywood that were part of Warner Brothers. I met guys that were Elvis Presley stunt double back in the day, and they really appreciated the real stunt people. And tell us a bit about Grantley Page.

I mean, what a legend. I mean, his work on Mad Max, and I know you were involved in Mad Max as well. Tell us a bit about Grant and his involvement.

But I was there in 1984 in Homebush in Sydney. Grantley was the stunt genius behind Mad Max 1 and Mad Max 3, the Thunderdome. Great bunch of people, a great time in history.

I miss them all. Most of them are gone. It was an honourable profession when I knew Grant.

The community in Australia of stunt people, especially in the early days. What's the one, the movie, which was a huge movie that Grant was in where he rode the motorcycle off the cliff, I think. Oh, that was Peter Armstrong.

That's called Stone with Sandy Harbert. Now, they hated Sandy Harbert, but he was a great

director and a great, great actor. And Peter Armstrong, well, you know, Peter was the best of the best, and he did that jump off the cliff.

He did that jump off the cliff, and he eventually ended up in Hollywood. And there was a great stuntman in Hollywood. Tell us about that person.

Who was that? 1986. His name was Dar Robinson, and he was an exceptional stuntman. I know that Peter and Dar got together when they were in Los Angeles in Trader Stories.

And your name, Dar Davis, is that a tribute to, because that was your stunt stage name, right? Well, because no one could pronounce my real name. Glynn, Glynn. And they call you Glenn, but it's Glynn.

That's G-L-Y-N-N, right? Well, you know, Dr. Glynn Davies. And you can be found, people can search you online if they put you in Google. There's all sorts of things about you in Google.

If you looked hard enough, you'd find me. Oh, definitely, definitely. I looked you up the other day, and there's so many references to you as Dar Davies.

So it's D-A-R, Davies, D-A-V-I-E-S. And you can see the whole history of Dar's incredible stunt career. And you are one of the absolute legends of Australian stunt personnel.

I think the people behind me are the Frank Lennons, the Grant Pages, the Ranganakoras, the Peter Armstrongs, the Bobby Woodhams. There's a great lineage behind me. I always had the utmost respects for my elders.

Those Easter shows, they were huge. And I actually remember seeing some of your compatriots there, too. Well, you see, they're all scared of heights.

And you're not scared of heights, and you've seen quite a few heights in your time. You see, hanging on a motorcycle when you're 220 foot off the ground, 800 feet out on a wire is not for the fainthearted. And I had a good fight with Keanu Reeves in the Matrix, is it? Oh, yeah, the Matrix.

Yeah, the Matrix. You were involved. Tell us about that.

Well, I just remembered, you know, they dressed us up, they shaved our heads, they put us in the police uniforms. I had a good time there. But I remember talking to Keanu, and I said, how are you going to handle this? And I said, just make, when you come near me, he kicked me in the head.

Just make it work. And he did? Yeah, of course he did. And once he kicked me in the head, I went down, right? So I say the same thing to other stunt people.

If I'm going to fight you, I will knock you right over. Because the camera will believe it, right? Exactly, yeah. So you were actually in the Matrix 1? I was there, yeah.

I was there, courtesy of a great stuntman called Glenn Boswell. Bossey. Bossey's a legend in the Australian stunt business.

He gave me the opportunity to be on set. I appreciate him for that. Glenn Boswell and Richard Bowie, they're really, really, you know, they're legends in the Australian film industry.

For the film people, that is. Glenn Davis, others known as Dar Davis, a stuntman extraordinaire in Australia. Thank you so much for being part of Travel Radio Australia.

Thank you, Geoff.